

Strategic Modeling — Module 07: Communication — Discussion Questions

20 questions on strategic narrative, signaling theory, brand positioning, and competitive communication.

1. How does Tesla's strategic communication simultaneously manage investor, customer, and competitor perceptions?
2. When is strategic ambiguity (being deliberately vague) a rational communication strategy?
3. How do credible signals differ from "cheap talk" in competitive communication? Give examples.
4. How does brand equity function as a shared generative model between the firm and its customers?
5. When should a company pre-announce a product or strategy? What are the risks of signaling too early?
6. How do investor narratives shape capital allocation decisions? What makes a narrative credible?
7. How does competitive signaling create a "conversation" between firms without direct communication?
8. When is it advantageous to signal weakness rather than strength? Give examples.
9. How do earnings calls function as a signaling mechanism between firms and capital markets?
10. What happens when a firm's strategic narrative diverges from its operational reality?
11. Analyze the strategic narrative of a company you know well. What story is it telling? To whom?
12. Design a competitive signaling strategy for a firm entering a market dominated by an incumbent.
13. Compare the strategic communication of two direct competitors. What does each signal?
14. Identify a case where a firm's strategic communication backfired. What went wrong?

15. How do ESG (environmental, social, governance) communications function as strategic signals?
16. Design a brand positioning strategy using the concept of "model alignment" between the firm and its target customers.
17. When a competitive signal is misinterpreted, what consequences can follow?
18. How do social media and viral communication change the dynamics of strategic signaling?
19. Is a company's leadership blog post a credible signal or cheap talk? What determines which?
20. Design a strategic communication plan for an organization undergoing a major pivot. How do you manage narratives for investors, employees, and customers simultaneously?